

A new shade of ambition

The Indian men's squad arrives at the Hockey World Cup with a new colour and cautious optimism, hoping recent gains under Craig Fulton can help them **bridge the gap** to the leading European sides.

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They say any publicity is good publicity. Or is it? The upcoming men's Hockey World Cup in the Netherlands and Belgium might have gone under the radar for many in India.

The national team is an outside bet for the title and would need to play out of its skin to challenge for a podium finish. **The World Cup, historically, hasn't been India's favoured playground — its last appearance in a final came way back in 1975, the year it won its only title.**

Privately, the team management might admit to itself that the quadrennial tournament isn't high on the pecking order among upcoming assignments. Three weeks after the World Cup concludes in Europe, India will head east to Japan for the much-fancied Asian Games, where an Olympic berth is up for grabs.

But Hockey India's (HI) bizarre choice to rip up its long-standing tradition of sporting blue in favour of

